nowhere near my best and found it difficult to maintain my balance in the middle.

England ended up winning the first Test comfortably, thanks to centuries from Pietersen and Prior and five wickets for James Anderson in the second innings. In the second Test at Trent Bridge, starting on 29 July, we came back strongly and Sreesanth and Ishant Sharma helped reduced England to 124–8 at one point in their first innings, but Swann and Broad managed to bail them out, taking their score to 221. It was still not a threatening total, however, and we passed it with six wickets in hand, only to lose them all for just twenty runs, with Broad taking six wickets in the innings, and the match slipped from our grasp.

After failing to win the second Test from a position of strength, things gradually went from bad to worse. The pain in my foot was not going away, and as a team we were outplayed yet again in the Third Test, which did not start in the best of circumstances, with riots in Birmingham creating a very tense atmosphere. The shopping centre next to our hotel was vandalized and there was talk of cancelling the tour. It was only after we were given an assurance that things were under control that the match went ahead.

In fact, this was not the only time that off-the-field events threatened to disrupt the tour. Before the one-day series, a match against Kent in Canterbury caused us all a lot of worry. In the closing stages of the game we noticed a large number of security personnel hovering near the dressing room. We were told that a suspect package had been found on the team bus and the bomb squad were on their way. Then we were asked to go and wait on the field because the dressing room was close to the danger area. We all waited patiently until we were finally told that we could leave by the back entrance of the ground. There was yet another bomb scare at night in the shopping arcade next to our hotel and a number of the players were starting to feel anxious about our security. The following morning we were told that things were fully under control and eventually the tour continued.

In the third Test at Edgbaston, England won the match with their first-innings total of 710, which included a career-best 294 from Alastair Cook and 104 from Eoin Morgan. I was pleased to bat well in the second innings and I don’t think anyone would deny I was unlucky to get out for 40. MS Dhoni had played a straight drive off Graeme Swann and the ball hit Swann’s hand and ricocheted onto the stumps at the non-striker’s end,